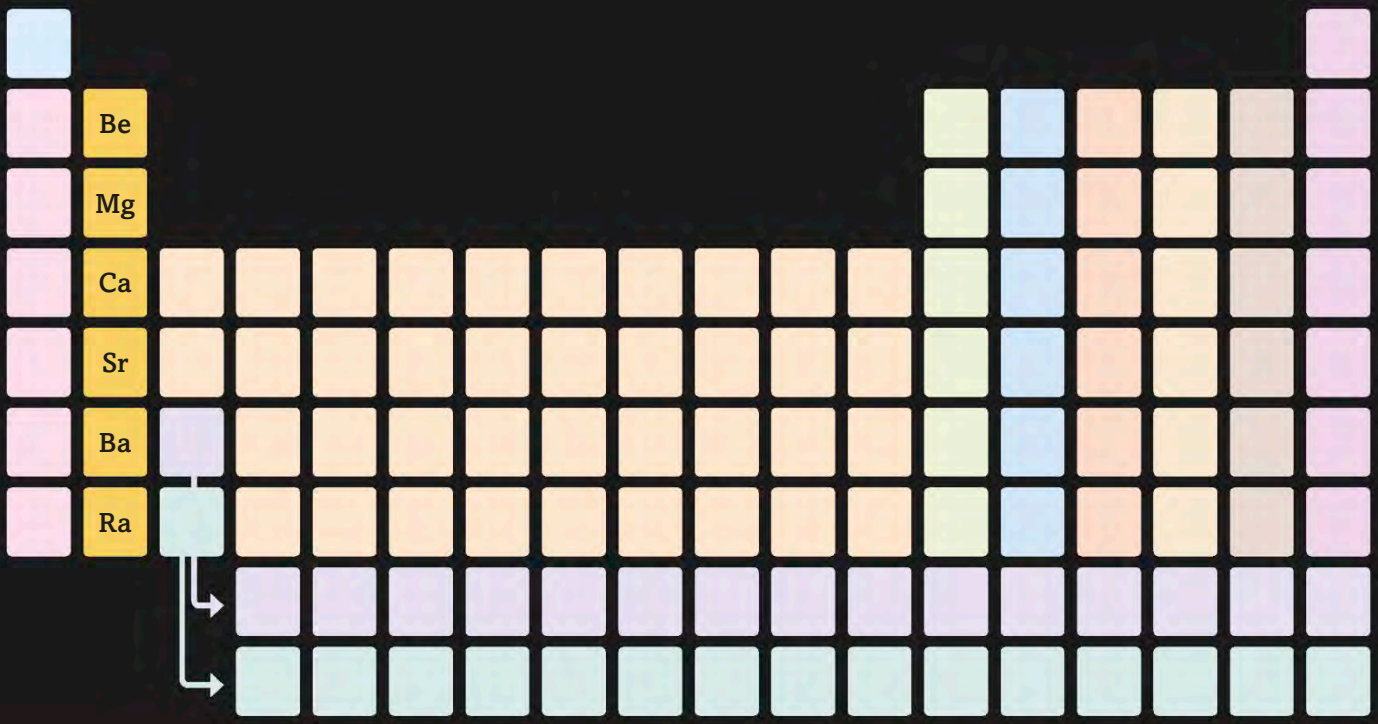

Alkaline Earth Metals

This group is a collection of reactive metals that were discovered as compounds inside common minerals in Earth's crust. Most of these minerals – known in the past as "earths" – are alkaline (alkali-producing), and this is how the group got its name. All alkaline earth metals were first purified in the 19th century.

Atomic structure
The alkaline earth metals have two electrons in their outermost electron shell. Radium (Ra) is the most radioactive member.

Physical properties
All members of this group are soft and shiny when pure. They are solid at room temperature.

Chemical properties
These metals are similar to the alkali metals, but not as reactive. Except for beryllium (Be), all alkaline earth metals react with hot water or steam.

Compounds
These elements form compounds with non-metals by losing their outermost electrons. Several compounds are found in teeth and bones.